

Nostalgia

This month I took a trip down memory lane. It started with my NAS drive failing me, and thus needing me to run out and buy another backup drive to safeguard all my data. I have years of pictures on that thing, and now I have two copies of everything – I learnt my lesson after that silly 3 TB NAS started clicking away.

Even though I bought a 6 TB backup drive now, I couldn't help look through all the stuff I'd backed up over the years. I'm a digital squirrel, and thus, I have everything. Literally. From old outlook PST backups from 2003, all the way to research done for my first few articles for Digit... pictures, games, music from the days when MP3 collections were things to be shown off... you name it, I had it.

I spent a good hour or so looking at the older DVD interfaces we had, and for the life of me I can't remember why we switched to this horrible iPad looking one. (Note to self: remember to sit down soon and finally get it changed to something less ugly.) There was a lot of reminiscing as well, and I was transported back to the two months I spent at office (barely going home four or five nights in that time) building the Windows OS looking interface.

Most importantly, I rediscovered my game backups (CD-rips; because CDs used to get scratched). There sat the good old NES emulator. Obviously I had to fire up DOS-Box and Nestopia and play *Super Mario Bros* for a couple of days – versions 1 and 3, because *Super Mario Bros 2* sucked! Then it was *Contra* for like a few hours (I got bored once I got the old skill level back and stopped dying even on speed runs), and then I saw AOE.ISO!

Not only did I have the original *Age Of Empires*, I also had the updates stored there, with the *Rise of Rome* expansion! That was it. I don't remember anything for a week after that, it was just binge-playing AOE every minute of free time I could spare, and also late into the night, because sacrificing sleep for AOE is just how we did things back in the day. I do miss those crazy LAN battles – we used to play with instant build and resource cheats allowed to make the game more interesting, and boy was it fun to hear the clackity-clack of furious typing when you started attacking a friend's town, and he realised he had run low on some resources! Ah, the good old days.

Another blast from the past I had this month was news of the Vivaldi browser being launched by the original guys behind the Opera browser. As a really old Opera user, who'd all but forgotten about Opera, Firefox and IE, I'd resigned myself to forevermore using Chrome. Although Vivaldi uses the same Chromium platform that also powers Google Chrome, it's also got all the best things about Opera. For a mouse user like me, just getting native mouse gestures back in the browser is a good enough reason for me to be loving it.

It's got its fair share of niggles and bugs, but it's nothing deal breaking for me, to be honest. I don't yet know whether it's my blast from the past mood this month that's got me loving Vivaldi, or a genuinely well-built new browser, but I've taken the plunge and set it as my default. I really wish the almost daily updates could be incremental, instead of me having to download the whole ~40 MB installer everyday. Though in this day and age, 40 MB doesn't really seem like too much anyway... try it out and tell me what you think.

I certainly encourage you all to take a trip down memory lane and revisit and play some retro games, reinstall your favourite old software (on a virtual machine), etc. Even if you are way too young to remember the old games, I still encourage you to give them a go – they can be incredibly addictive and fun. AOE, especially, is super fun to use cheats in, and get laser-firing troopers and cars with a nuclear rocket-launcher killing cavalry and foot soldiers! Talk about overkill...

Another game I've often gone back to playing is *Ascendancy*, which is a really old turn-based space strategy game. Maybe it was because I loved the idea of space exploration that I got hooked on it, but whatever the reason, that's another game I play for days on end about once a year. Then, of course, there's good old *Quake III*, which is a Team Digit staple for a quick competitive round of fragging to blow off some steam.

I'm sure we all have some retro games or habits, and I'd love to hear what yours are. So what do you do when you're in a nostalgic mood? 



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